

Chapter 34 — Hithpael Semantic Function Sorting

BBH Chapter 34 · Hithpael Strong Verbs

Classify each Hithpael verb: R (Reflexive), RC (Reciprocal), IT (Iterative/Frequentative), ES (Estimative/Declarative), or DN (Denominative). Answer key is on the last page.

R = Reflexive (subject acts on itself) | RC = Reciprocal (subjects act on one another) | IT = Iterative/Frequentative (repeated or habitual action) | ES = Estimative (subject presents itself as being in a state) | DN = Denominative (derived from a noun)

#	Hebrew	Conjugation	Ref	Contextual Gloss	Function
1	מִתְהַלֵּךְ	Participle ms	Gen 3:8	"walking about (in the garden)"	
2	יִתְחַבֵּא	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 3:8	"he hid himself"	
3	יִתְהַלֵּךְ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 5:22	"Enoch walked about (with God)"	
4	יִתְעַצֵּב	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 6:6	"he was grieved (to his heart)"	
5	יִתְגַּל	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 9:21	"he uncovered himself"	
6	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Imperative 2ms	Gen 13:17	"walk about (through the land)!"	
7	הִתְעַנֵּי	Imperative 2fs	Gen 16:9	"humble yourself!"	
8	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Imperative 2ms	Gen 17:1	"walk about before me!"	
9	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 18:2	"he prostrated himself"	
10	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 19:1	"Lot bowed down"	
11	יִתְפַּלֵּל	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 20:17	"he prayed"	
12	הִתְבָּרְכוּ	Weqatal 3cp	Gen 22:18	"they will bless themselves / be blessed"	
13	הִתְהַלַּכְתִּי	Qatal 1cs	Gen 24:40	"I have walked about (before the LORD)"	
14	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 24:26	"he bowed down and worshiped"	
15	הִתְעַשְׂקוּ	Qatal 3cp	Gen 26:20	"they quarreled"	
16	מִתְנַחֵם	Participle ms	Gen 27:42	"is comforting himself"	
17	יִתְנַכְּלוּ	Wayyiqtol 3mp	Gen 37:18	"they plotted against him"	
18	וַיִּתְאַבֵּל	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 37:34	"he mourned"	
19	תִּתְכַּסֶּה	Wayyiqtol 3fs	Gen 24:65	"she covered herself"	
20	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3mp	Gen 33:7	"they bowed down"	
21	אֶתְנַהֵּלָה	Cohortative 1cs	Gen 33:14	"I will journey on slowly"	
22	הִתְקַדְּשׁוּ	Imperative 2mp	Exo 19:22	"consecrate yourselves!"	
23	וַיִּתְחַזַּק	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Exo 7:13	"and his heart was strengthened"	
24	יִתְהַלְּלוּ	Wayyiqtol 3mp	Ps 97:7	"they glory in idols"	
25	הִתְחַזַּקָּה	Imperative 2mp	Jos 1:6	"be strong!"	

1. ■■■■■■ appears 5 times (items 1, 3, 6, 8, 13). Why is this Iterative rather than Reflexive? What does "walking about" add that a single-step Qal walk does not?
2. Item 12 (■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■, Gen 22:18) can be translated "bless themselves" (R) or "be blessed" (passive). What would change if you read this as passive?
3. Items 24–25 are Estimative. What does the Hithpael add to ■■■■■■ and ■■■■■■ that the Qal of the same root would not express?

Answer Key

#	Hebrew	Ref	Fn	Explanation
1	מִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 3:8	IT	Back-and-forth movement; not a single walk
2	יִתְחַבֵּא	Gen 3:8	R	Subject acts on itself; concealment
3	יִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 5:22	IT	Habitual/continuous walking; same root as #1
4	יִתְעַצֵּב	Gen 6:6	R	Inward grief; the LORD's heart acts on itself
5	יִתְגַּל	Gen 9:21	R	Reflexive uncovering; subject = object
6	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 13:17	IT	Command to traverse repeatedly; same root
7	הִתְעַנֵּי	Gen 16:9	R	Reflexive self-humbling; subject acts on itself
8	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 17:1	IT	Continuous conduct before YHWH
9	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Gen 18:2	R	Reflexive prostration; III-he Hithpael
10	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Gen 19:1	R	Same form; Lot prostrates himself before the angels
11	יִתְפַּלֵּל	Gen 20:17	DN	From פָּלַל "mediation/judgment"; to mediate/intercede
12	הִתְבָּרַךְ	Gen 22:18	R	Reflexive blessing; can also be read as passive-like
13	הִתְהַלֵּכְתִּי	Gen 24:40	IT	Continuous habitual conduct
14	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Gen 24:26	R	Same form; servant prostrates himself
15	הִתְעַשְׂקוּ	Gen 26:20	RC	Mutual quarreling; the herdsmen act on one another
16	מִתְנַחֵם	Gen 27:42	R	Esau comforting himself with the thought of revenge
17	יִתְנַגְּלוּ	Gen 37:18	RC	Collective/mutual scheming against Joseph
18	יִתְאַבֵּל	Gen 37:34	R	Inward grief expressed outwardly; reflexive mourning
19	תִּתְכַסֶּה	Gen 24:65	R	Rebekah covered herself with her veil
20	יִשְׁתַּחֲוּוּ	Gen 33:7	R	Jacob's wives and children prostrate themselves
21	אֶתְהַלֵּלָה	Gen 33:14	IT	Iterative/continuous slow travel; guiding the flocks
22	הִתְקַדְּשׁוּ	Exo 19:22	R	The priests prepare themselves for the theophany
23	יִתְחַזַּק	Exo 7:13	R	The heart strengthened itself / became stubborn
24	יִתְהַלֵּל	Ps 97:7	ES	Present themselves as glorious; boast in idols
25	הִתְחַזְּקוּ	Jos 1:6	ES	Present/conduct yourselves as strong; estimative force